would bring in a similar brand of unilateral decision-making which was not part of the BJP's culture,' says an Advani loyalist. Advani also told BJP leaders who met him that he was convinced that if Modi became the face of the BJP campaign, it would lead to a Hindu–Muslim polarization and the core issue of governance and UPA misrule would be forgotten. 'We will not get allies and we will be stuck with 180 seats like in 1996,' he warned.

The truth is, Advani had never reconciled himself to the 2009 defeat under his helmsmanship. There were reports (denied, of course) that he would consult astrologers on when the Manmohan Singh government would fall. He even seemed to blame me for denying him his moment of ultimate glory, in an episode that revealed the darker side of our politics.

The cash-for-votes scandal had broken out during the nuclear deal vote in Parliament in 2008. There had been much speculation at the time that MPs were being offered bribes by both sides but we were not being given any evidence. CPI leader A.B. Bardhan had even claimed that Rs 25 crore was being offered to each MP for their vote. Our investigative reporter Siddharth Gautam had been attempting to get more details but had made no significant breakthrough. I was sitting in Parliament's central hall listening to the nuclear debate when Jaitley joined us. The BJP leader claimed some of his MPs had been contacted by the government to switch sides. 'We are planning to expose this in a sting operation,' he said. He agreed to allow our cameras to be a fly on the wall, watching MPs being 'purchased'.

That evening, we got a phone call from Jaitley, and sent Siddharth and a production unit to meet Sudheendra Kulkarni who was supervising the entire sting operation. The silver-haired Kulkarni, a former journalist, had worked in the Vajpayee PMO. He was now an Advani loyalist with an obsessive desire to see his leader as prime minister. Kulkarni had also played an important role in shaping Advani's contentious homage to Jinnah. Now, he was hoping that the sting would bring down the Manmohan Singh government. With Kulkarni were three BJP MPs, Ashok Argal, Faggan Singh Kulaste and Mahavir Bhagora, who had offered to be 'whistle-blowers'. None of us had met or heard of these MPs till that day.